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“WIPE THEM OUT”

Tuesday, October 16, began for John Kennedy like any other day, reading newspapers. He had a habit of doing that first thing in the morning, while still in bed. That morning he could not miss the lead article in the *New York Times* covering the reception he had given Ahmed Ben Bella, the prime minister of newly independent Algeria. The article was accompanied by the photo of Jackie Kennedy and the president’s twenty-two-month-old son, John Jr., watching the ceremony and a twenty-one-gun salute from behind the bushes of the White House Rose Garden. Ben Bella, released from a French prison slightly more than three months earlier, had come to the White House to discuss bilateral relations and thank Kennedy for his support of his country’s anticolonial struggle. He did so publicly, and the coverage was good for Kennedy.[1]

Also quite favorable was the coverage in the *Washington Post*, whose reporter wrote that “the president disabused Ben Bella of any ambitions that he might serve as a mediator between the United States and Cuba.” In fact,